

7. Phone analysis, interrogation lead ATS teams to Sheikh and Khan; the duo arrested from a highway motel in Banaskantha at 4 am



8. UP Police raid Khan's house in Lakhimpur Kheri, recover an ISIS flag, digital devices; Gujarat ATS, with Telangana Police, raids Saiyyad's house in Hyderabad. Recovery: raw material and equipment for ricin production



9. ATS says the men had surveyed potential targets in Delhi, Lucknow and Ahmedabad, got Rs 2 lakh for ferrying arms; handler is an Afghanistan-based ISKP operative

WHEN OFFICERS FROM GUJARAT'S Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) closed in on a silver Ford Figo with an Andhra Pradesh registration near a toll plaza on the Ahmedabad–Mehsana Road around 9:30 pm on November 7, they believed they were intercepting a gun-running operation linked to a terror plan. The tip-off was precise; the car had been under surveillance for some hours. But within minutes of stopping it, the team realised they had stumbled onto something far more alarming: a suspected plot involving ricin, one of the world's deadliest toxins. It soon unspooled into a multi-state investigation, exposing India's vulnerabilities to low-cost, high-impact bioterror.

Inside the car was Dr Ahmed Mohiyuddin Saiyyad, a 32-year-old China-trained doctor from Hyderabad. From him, officers recovered three pistol—two Glocks and one Beretta—and 30 live cartridges. His arrest quickly led investigators to two younger associates from Uttar Pradesh—20-year-old tailor Azad Suleman Sheikh of Shamli and 23-year-old student Mohammad Suhail Khan of Lakhimpur Kheri. The duo was picked up from a highway motel in Banaskantha, about 150 kilometres north of Gandhinagar.

The ATS soon pieced together the sequence. The weapons were first received in Tibbi, a borderside village in Rajasthan's Hanumangarh district, and are believed to have been delivered by drone—a method now common in narcotics and small-arms drops from Pakistan. From there, Sheikh and Khan allegedly collected the consignment from an unknown intermediary and transported it to a secluded spot near Kalol in Gandhinagar, not far from the Adalaj toll plaza, where Saiyyad was later stopped after he picked up the package.

But the doctor was carrying something else: four litres of castor oil. That's what raised the first serious suspicions. On its own, the oil is ubiquitous—Gujarat is among the world's largest producers. Yet in concentrated quantities, with the right equipment and expertise, it can be used to extract ricin, a toxin with no antidote. Physical evidence and interrogation, ATS officers say, suggest that ricin extraction was indeed the intention.

Further analysis of the trio's mobile phones revealed suspected links to the Islamic State–Khorasan Province (ISKP), the ISIS's regional arm active in Afghanistan, Pakistan and neighbouring regions. According to the ATS, their handler was Abu Khadija, ISKP's Afghanistan-based operative. The men had allegedly surveyed potential targets in Delhi, Lucknow and Ahmedabad—RSS offices and crowded public spaces among them—though investigators say they had not yet finalised a site to attack.

> **"The physical evidence in the case and interrogation of Dr Ahmed Mohiyuddin Saiyyad suggest that he intended to extract ricin"**
>
> **SUNIL JOSHI**
> *Deputy Inspector General, Anti-Terrorism Squad, Gujarat*



The arrests came just days before a car exploded near Red Fort in Delhi on November 10, a suspected suicide attack traced to a Faridabad-based terror module comprising doctors. The coincidence raised immediate speculation about a possible link. Gujarat ATS officials, however, have ruled out any connection. "The two